PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2

Repetition and sequence

Composers make one idea go a long way. They say it again, say it again higher or lower, let another hand copy it, or say something completely new.
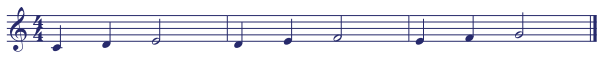
THE SECRET

Again, again higher, again in the other hand, or something new.
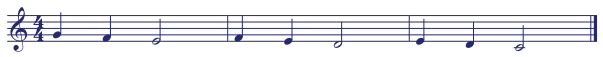


Four ways to use one idea

NAME	WHAT HAPPENS
repetition	the same notes again
sequence	the same shape, starting higher or lower
imitation	another hand or voice copies the idea
contrast	something new: a different shape or rhythm



A rising sequence: C D E, D E F, E F G.

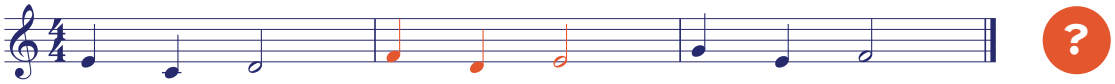


A falling sequence: each step one note lower.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Take any three-note motif and play it as a sequence, starting on every white key from C up to the next C, then back down.

EXAMPLE 1

Repetition or sequence?
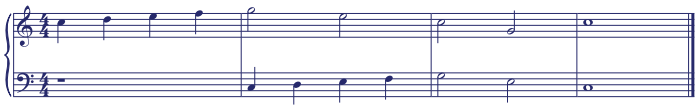


1. **Bar 1:** which notes?
2. **Bar 2:** the same notes, or the same shape on new notes?
3. **Bar 3?**

Same shape, a step higher each bar: a **sequence**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand copies?
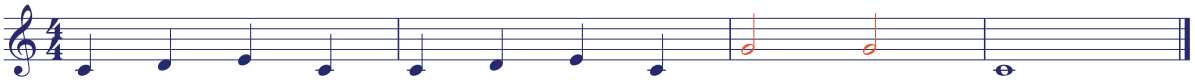


1. **The right hand** starts with C D E F G E C.
2. **The left hand** waits a bar. Then?
3. **Same notes**, how many octaves lower?

The left hand **imitates** the right one bar later, two octaves down.

EXAMPLE 3

Where is the contrast?



1. **Bars 1 and 2:** same or different?
2. **Bar 3:** what changes, the notes or the rhythm?
3. **Bar 4?**

Bars 1–2 repeat; **bar 3** brings something new: long notes on G.

GAME

Which way?

1 same notes

2 one step up

3 left hand copies

4 new rhythm

Name each one.

Answer: 1 repetition · 2 sequence · 3 imitation · 4 contrast.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
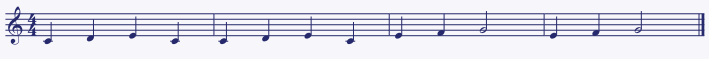


Make a sequence.

Play C D E, then D E F, then E F G with fingers 1 2 3. Now go down: G F E, F E D, E D C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques



Every bar is said **twice**: repetition. Sung as a round, each voice enters two bars after the last: imitation.

Try it. Sing it as a round with a friend.

TRAP

× Calling any repeat a sequence: a sequence moves to new notes.

SEE ALSO
Motifs and phrases p. 144 · Texture p. 148

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Patterns